Safari, but never showed the images. We did exercise self-restraint but clearly the government wanted a total blackout. ‘Are you trying to spark off another riot?’ Pramod Mahajan angrily asked me over the phone. I felt it was important to mirror the ugly reality on the ground—an impactful story, I hoped, would push the Centre into sending the army to the battle-scarred streets.

I did not encounter Modi till the evening of 2 March when he held a press conference at the circuit house in Ahmedabad to claim that the situation was being brought under control with the help of the army. That morning, though, he had rung me up to warn me about our coverage which he said was inflammatory. In particular, he told me about the report of an incident in Anjar, Kutch, of a Hanuman temple being attacked, which he said was totally false. ‘Some roadside linga was desecrated, but no temple has been touched. I will not allow such malicious and provocative reporting,’ he said angrily. I tried to explain to him that the report had come through a news wire agency and had been flashed by our Delhi newsroom without verifying with me. A few hours later, the chief minister’s office issued orders banning the telecast of the channel.

Modi’s press conference also took place against the backdrop of a front-page story in that morning’s *Times of India* indicating that the chief minister had invoked Newton’s law to suggest that the violence was a direct reaction to Godhra. ‘Every action invites an equal and opposite reaction’, was the headline. Modi denied having made any such remark to the reporter. Naturally, the mood at the press conference was frosty and hostile.

After the press conference, I reached out to Modi, assuring him we would be even more careful in our coverage. I offered to interview him so that he could send out a strong message of calm and reassurance. He agreed. We did the interview, only to return to the office and find the tape damaged. I telephoned Modi’s office again, explained the problem and managed to convince him to do another interview, this time in Gandhinagar later that night.

We reached the chief minister’s residence in Gandhinagar a little after 10 p.m. We dined with him and then recorded the interview. I asked him about